

Something new, something borrowed

Apple recently unveiled iOS 7, which a lot of people were waiting for with baited breath. After all, design maestro Jonathan Ive was going to be behind this one, and he has the notoriety of being willing to break tradition and build from scratch.

It's been no secret that I'm pretty critical of Apple, and that I hate the way they sometimes market ordinary features as if they've just made wine from rocks. Actually, everyone kind of does that, it's the way the game's played I suppose, but perhaps it's the devoted iPeople I've come across who have really irked me. Just because Steve said it, doesn't make it the Gospel!

I'm not particularly religious, nor am I a "fan" of anything – except Manchester United to some extent, though I'm pretty critical of them as well. Surprisingly, I've had more rational debates with devoutly religious people of all religions than I've ever been able to have with some Apple "fans". Fitting, I suppose, since the very word is a shortened form of "fanatics".

Getting back to iOS, there already seem to be arguments starting online as to whether Apple's "copied", or "been inspired by", Windows, Android, BlackBerry 10, and even Palm's WebOS. This was expected, because radical changes bring comparisons to all that have gone before. Creativity itself is so subjective and usually inspired, that for all practical purposes, nit-pickers will always find "influences".

A lot of new songs you hear, if scrutinised, sound like they've been inspired by some other. Perhaps the composer's never heard the other song before, and since there are only 12 distinct notes in western music, there's bound to be note progressions (melodies) that sound similar.

However, can Apple's team claim the same ignorance? You can bet your life that every one of these companies watches every OS release by every other company like a hawk. With a trillion dollars at stake, they'd better be! Just as everyone watches what Apple is doing, so does Apple watch everyone else.

So what if iOS7 looks like it borrowed a few ideas from Palm / Android / Windows 8? It's not the end of the world, unless you're a fanboy and you take that as an insult to your very being. Apple's never really "invented" anything ground-breaking that we use today... but neither have the other big companies. It

is researchers at good colleges such as MIT, smaller companies that get bought over, and some really creative individuals that do most of the real inventing anyway. What successful companies do best is identify a trend before it becomes one, buy into ideas before they're big, modify good ideas into great ones, not be stuck-up enough to change, and most importantly, allow themselves to be inspired by others.

Even Sachin Tendulkar learnt the techniques of playing the perfect straight drive by watching others do it, footballing god Messi was inspired by someone, and Michael Jackson took a little inspiration from street dancers to invent his Moonwalk. So why should we hold Jonathan Ive and his team to any higher standards? Identifying what works best – regardless of who first used it – takes great maturity, and adopting something that's not totally "new" into a flagship product line of one of the world's biggest companies takes courage.

The only constant in the technology world is change, and even Steve Jobs knew that, as far back as 1994, where he once said in an interview, "All the work I have done in my life will be obsolete by the time I'm 50."

Personally, I welcome the fact that Apple is looking to be more user-friendly and intuitive, regardless of whether it gets called a copycat. The lines blurring between UIs is a good thing, and will make switches to different platforms easier for people; it will level the playing field, and allow you to choose what's best, instead of sticking to a platform for the sake of loyalty.

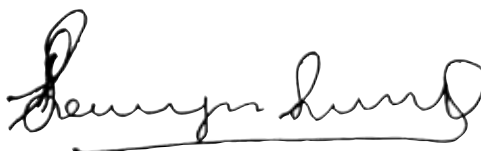
I think I'm going to like the new iOS 7, more than any versions before it, but I'm not going to put blinders on and think only Apple contributed to making it the way it is. We have Android, Windows and WebOS developers to thank for the new Apple OS as well, and admitting that isn't Apple-bashing.

Personally, I'd just like Apple videos to be less preachy and sound less like evangelism – www.apple.com/ios/ios7/design/ – but maybe that's just me. Or is it? 



Robert Sovereign-Smith
Executive Editor
editor@thinkdigit.com

**"Apple's never really
"invented" anything
ground-breaking
that we use today...
but neither have
the other big
companies."**



Liked or hated this column?
Write in to editor@thinkdigit.com and
let me know your thoughts.